



DESTINATION FILE

Uluru–Kata Tjuta

One of Earth's most sacred landscapes — a place of living culture, not just a natural wonder.

COUNTRY

Aṅangu Country, NT

ACCESS

Fly to Ayers Rock (AYQ)

PAX RANKING

#3 of all destinations

STATUS

● Open · climbing banned

01 Destination overview

LOCATION & SIZE

Uluru is a sandstone monolith 348m high and 9.4 km around, in the southern Northern Territory. With the domes of Kata Tjuta 40 km west, it forms Uluru–Kata Tjuta National Park — a UNESCO dual World Heritage Site for both natural and cultural value.

CHARACTER

One of the most sacred landscapes on Earth for its Aṅangu Traditional Owners. A place of profound cultural and spiritual significance, not simply a natural landmark — this framing must shape every client interaction.

ACCESS

Fly to Ayers Rock Airport (AYQ) at Yulara — direct services from Sydney, Melbourne, Brisbane, Cairns and Alice Springs. There is no practical alternative to flying for most visitors — an honest limitation of the destination.

BEST SEASON

May–September (cooler months) — best for walking, daytime temperatures manageable. December–February — extreme heat, walks close above 36°C. Sunrise and sunset are the iconic viewing times year-round.

GOVERNING BODIES

- Parks Australia
- Uluṛu–Kata Tjuṛa Board of Management
- Aṇangu Traditional Owners
- Central Land Council

LEGAL FRAMEWORKS

- EPBC Act 1999
- Aboriginal Land Rights Act 1976
- Park lease & joint management plan
- Climbing prohibition (2019)

02 Aṇangu Traditional Owners & Tjukurpa

TRADITIONAL OWNERS

The Aṇangu are the Traditional Owners of Uluṛu–Kata Tjuṛa, with a continuous culture stretching back tens of thousands of years. The park is jointly managed by Aṇangu and Parks Australia, with traditional law guiding decisions.

TJUKURPA

Tjukurpa is the foundation of Aṇangu culture — law, knowledge, religion, and the relationships between people, land and all living things. It governs every aspect of how the land is cared for and how visitors should behave.

CLIMBING IS PERMANENTLY PROHIBITED

Climbing Uluṛu has been banned since 26 October 2019. The climb crossed a sacred men's ceremonial track tied to Tjukurpa. This is a legal prohibition, not a preference — communicate it to every client without exception.

PRIORITY RECOMMENDATION

Begin every itinerary at the Cultural Centre, and include an Aṇangu-guided experience such as the Maruku Arts dot-painting workshop or a SEIT Outback Australia cultural tour led by Traditional Owners.

03 Sustainability & current status

CULTURAL SUSTAINABILITY

The greatest sustainability priority at Uluru is cultural, not environmental. Respecting Tjukurpa, photography restrictions and sacred-site closures is the core responsibility of every visitor and operator.

PHOTOGRAPHY RULES

Some areas of Uluru are permanently off-limits to photography — marked by signs — because they depict sacred sites. Always check signage, and always ask permission before photographing Anangu people. Commercial photography requires a Parks Australia permit.

ENVIRONMENTAL CARE

Stay on marked tracks

Carry out all rubbish

Don't remove rock or soil

Respect water sources

Feral animal & buffel grass management

BEFORE YOU SELL

Brief clients on cultural protocols before arrival — not on the day. Set expectations that climbing is banned, that some sites cannot be photographed, and that this is a place of living culture deserving deep respect.

04 Environment & landscape

GEOLOGY

Uluru is the visible tip of a vast rock slab extending kilometres underground. Its colour shifts dramatically with the light — most spectacularly at sunrise and sunset — due to iron oxidation on its surface.

DESERT ECOLOGY

Red kangaroos

Dingoes

Thorny devils

Perentie monitors

Zebra finches

Desert wildflowers (after rain)

Mulga & spinifex

KATA TJUṬA

The 36 domes of Kata Tjuṭa rise higher than Uluru. The Valley of the Winds and Walpa Gorge walks pass through them — terrain here is rugged and walks close in extreme heat.

HEAT & SAFETY — CRITICAL

Uluṛu's extreme heat (up to 50°C) is a genuine medical risk. Walks close automatically above 36°C. The nearest hospital is Alice Springs — 450 km away. Ensure clients carry water (1L per hour), sun protection, and travel insurance with medical evacuation cover.

05 Getting there sustainably

PRIMARY ACCESS

Fly to Ayers Rock Airport (AYQ) at Yulara — there is no practical low-carbon alternative for most visitors. Prefer direct flights over connections via Alice Springs where possible.

THE GHAN

Some travellers combine Uluṛu with Alice Springs and join The Ghan (Adelaide–Darwin) for part of a longer itinerary — a meaningful lower-carbon option for the overland leg.

ON THE GROUND

A free shuttle connects Yulara resort, airport and key sites. Hiring a car is common for reaching multiple sunrise/sunset viewing areas. No public transport runs between Yulara and the park sites.

HONEST FRAMING

Uluṛu is the most transport-challenged destination in the portfolio due to its remoteness. Acknowledge this with clients and recommend carbon offsetting for the flight legs as standard practice for this itinerary.

06 Accessibility

OVERALL

Good for a remote desert destination — most key experiences are accessible with planning.

ACCESSIBLE WALKS

The Kuniya Walk (1km return to Mutitjulu Waterhole) and Mala Walk (2km return) are on flat, maintained paths suitable for wheelchairs, with deep cultural significance. The full Uluṛu Base Walk (10.6km) is accessible on maintained sandy paths — a powered wheelchair or carer is recommended for the full circuit.

CULTURAL CENTRE

Fully accessible with ramps, paved paths and accessible facilities. Recommended as the first stop for every visitor.

VIEWING AREAS

All sunrise and sunset viewing areas are wheelchair accessible with paved surfaces and seating. The Valley of the Winds and Walpa Gorge walks at Kata Tjuta are not accessible — terrain is rugged.

HEAT & MEDICAL RISK

Extreme heat presents real risk for visitors with cardiovascular or heat-sensitive conditions. The nearest hospital is 450 km away. Clients with relevant conditions should consult a physician before travel and carry evacuation cover.

07 Eco-certified operators

CERTIFIED OPERATORS IN THIS REGION

OJ supplier	Ayers Rock Resort — Advanced Ecotourism · ROC
	Alice Springs Desert Park — Advanced Ecotourism · ROC
	Earth Sanctuary World Nature Centre — Advanced Ecotourism · ROC
	Mercure Alice Springs Resort — Sustainable Tourism

FULL CERTIFIED-OPERATOR REFERENCE

- ↓ OJ certified-operator reference (Excel) — curated by destination, with our suppliers flagged.
- ↓ Full Ecotourism Australia register (Excel) — the complete national source file, updated quarterly.

SOURCING & CURRENCY

Showing 1 current Orange Journeys supplier plus other certified operators in this region. Verified against the Ecotourism Australia register, April 2026. Certification status changes over time — confirm before booking at ecotourism.org.au. If you download either Excel file, don't keep working from a saved copy — return to the Hub and download the latest version each time, as both the OJ reference and the full Ecotourism Australia register are updated regularly.

Sources — Parks Australia · Uluru–Kata Tjuṯa National Park Board of Management · Central Land Council · Tourism NT. Reviewed at least every 12 months.

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